

Radius

Sustaining Dublin

Gillian Murtagh explores the influx of green industry around Dublin, and how the growing trend of environmentalism in the city is here to stay.

TCD SU ELECTIONS

The Elections Analysed

Our elections team look at the five TCD SU officer races, speaking to the candidates and those currently in the positions about the major issues and how they interpret the roles up for grabs in analysis, pages 15-17 »

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En Garde with DUFC

Jonathan Fischer looks at the success of Dublin University Fencing Club, one of the most renowned clubs in the country and where students have been duelling since 1774 in sport, page 18 »

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Brexit and the future of Northern Ireland's border

The University Times

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Student Publication of the Year

Tuesday 31 January, 2017

New Research Initiative Criticised After Concerns Over Ranking Academics

Róisín Power and Sinéad Baker

A new initiative to measure the research output of Trinity's staff, currently in its pilot phase, has raised concerns that it might potentially rank and compare individual academics, already drawing criticism from a trade union. The new initiative, Principal Investigator Quantitative Analytics, is proposing to rank academics based on their research output. The initiative has faced criticism in College, including from the Irish Federation of University Teachers (IFUT). Speaking to *The University Times* in his capacity of Trinity

Branch Chair of IFUT, Dr John Walsh of the School of Education said that "I think there are concerns among many staff members, and certainly IFUT members, throughout College. We think that it's really counter to the whole spirit of the academic community". "Much of PIQA [Principal Investigator Quantitative Analytics] is quite reasonable and consists mainly of information gathering about, say, research income and other aspects of research, which we would have no objection to", Walsh added. However, describing the proposed idea of ranking academics as "problematic", Walsh commented that it is "effectively individual benchmarking or individual league tables" and that it would

"potentially involve comparing individual academics based on a small number of criteria such as grant applications, total journal articles or web of science citations". A response issued by College spokesperson, Caoimhe Ni Lochlainn, on behalf of the Dean of Research, Prof John Boland, confirmed that the project was in its pilot stage, but declined to comment until the initiative had been fully rolled out. In the UK, the Research Excellence Framework is used to assess the quality of academic research, with results used to determine how much research funding universities and academics are granted, as well as an institu-

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Only 1% of Arts Faculty Property in "Good Condition", With Planned €4m Arts Block Refurbishment

Dominic McGrath

DEPUTY EDITOR

Only one per cent of the properties owned by the Faculty of Arts, Humanities and Social Sciences (AHSS) are in "good condition", according to a report submitted to the College Board and obtained by *The University Times*, as Trinity prepares for a €4 million refurbishment of the Arts Block. The report, which was submitted to the Board last December, found that 82 per cent of the faculty's property requires "modernisation", while only 10 per cent is described

as "operationally safe". While seven per cent of the faculty's property is categorised as "new", this is all found in the School of Business. None of the other 12 schools across the faculty had any buildings that were in good condition, with the exception of the School of Histories and Humanities. Trinity is currently preparing a €4 million refurbishment of the Arts Block, which accounts for 30 per cent of the total property in the faculty. While it still needs to be approved by College, the refurbishment was announced by Provost Patrick Prendergast, speaking at Trinity College Dublin Students' Union (TCD SU) council last week,

alongside Trinity's Bursar, Veronica Campbell, who is currently working on a business case for the project. In an email statement to *The University Times*, Campbell said she plans to tender for a designer for a feasibility study in the next month, with the hope of beginning the work over the summer of 2018 and 2019. One way the project, she said, will "improve the student experience is through improvements to the open spaces in the corridors by creating break-out spaces for informal learning". Not all AHSS schools are located in the Arts Block,

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Proposal Would See Removal of Special Examinations and Pass by Compensation

- » Off-books could count as repeated year
- » Consultation with staff and students planned

Róisín Power

NEWS EDITOR

An early-stage proposal would remove pass by compensation and discontinue special examinations, better known as "super sups", *The University Times* has learned, as part of changes under the Trinity Education Project. The proposal, authored by

the Senior Lecturer, Dr Gillian Martin, and seen by *The University Times*, was submitted to the College's Undergraduate Studies Committee on Tuesday January 24th, by the Progression and Awards working group of the Trinity Education Project. The project is a university-wide reimagining of how Trinity's undergraduates are taught, prepared and assessed, that first began as a review of the undergraduate curriculum during the 2012/13 academic year. One of the most significant proposals would end pass by compensation, which is often used to allow students to pass a year on the strength of

their average mark, despite having failed a module. It also allows students to pass a module, or in some cases, two modules, if they are the only modules failed. The proposal states that "all modules must be passed in all years. Compensation is not permitted". The proposal also recommends that special examinations, usually referred to as "super sups", be discontinued. These exams are sat during the first weeks of Michaelmas term by students who have received approval to sit an exam after the first supplemental examination period. Students who receive "super sups" typically

get them on medical grounds, or due to unforeseen, extraordinary circumstances where it was not possible for them to take their exam during the supplemental examinations period. In an email statement to *The University Times*, Martin declined to answer specific questions on the nature of the proposals. She noted, however, that "a number of preliminary recommendations from the working group on progressions and awards were brought to [Undergraduate Studies Committee] for initial discussion and feedback". Discussion will

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RAG Week Comes into Bloom



PHOTO BY ANNA MORAN FOR THE UNIVERSITY TIMES

RAG week kicks off On Monday night, the Rose of Trinity was held in The Sugar Club to raise money for Trinity Vincent de Paul. Both male and female roses took to the stage with fake petals and an abundance of doubtful talent.

The Difficulty in Providing More Student Accommodation

Simon Foy examines how colleges are dealing with the ongoing student accommodation crisis and how they are limited in what they can provide. PAGE 11 »



Tackling Trinity on LGBT Employment Equality

Dominic McGrath speaks to the lecturer who took Trinity to the European Courts of Justice and lost, yet who is still fighting what he sees as discrimination. PAGE 10 »



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The Riptide Movement and Wilkinson Set to Play Trinity Ball

Gillian Murtagh

RADIUS EDITOR

The Riptide Movement, Wilkinson, SG Lewis and Nick Johnson have been added to the line-up for Trinity Ball 2017, *The University Times* can reveal. Headliners for the ball have still yet to be announced. The Riptide Movement are a four-man rock band originally from Lucan, Dublin, comprising of vocalist Mal Tuohy, guitarist John Dalton, bassist and harmonica player Ger McGarry and drummer Gar Byrne. Their latest album, *Ghosts*, was released in October 2016, after being recorded in the US. The band are set to play the Olympia on March 17th after a string of German dates in February. The Riptide Movement is re-

nowned for the energy that they bring to their live sets, with hits such as "All Works Out" and "You and I" being consistently played with enthusiasm and passion. Their addition to the line-up follows an ongoing Trinity Ball tradition of including Irish acts on the bill. After the success of last year's line-up, which heavily featured electronic and dance acts, DJ and drum and bass music producer from London, Wilkinson has been added to this year's line-up. In the wake of huge underground success with tracks such as "Tonight" and "Automatic", Wilkinson released his debut album, *Lazers Not Included*, in 2013. In the past he has collaborated with the likes of Shannon Saunders, Gorgon City and René LaVice. Wilkinson boasts the ability to attract mainstream attention to

drum and bass music while staying true to the authenticity of the underground scene. "Flatline" with Wretch 32, the lead single from his second studio album, *Hypnotic*, was released in March 2016. After finishing a UK tour, Wilkinson will bring a much loved energy to the Trinity Ball dance floor that is sure to get everyone moving. SG Lewis is a music producer and singer-songwriter from London who is set to bring the diversity of his sound to the ball stage. Lewis's music channels sonic tones and instrumental elements, allowing them to contrast in a dynamic and engaging manner. The deep, soulful voices that feature present a unique fusion of R&B and house beats. Lewis released his debut EP, *Shivers*, in 2013, which gained him recognition from the likes of Pharrell Williams and Justin Timberlake.

In his latest release, *Yours*, he continues to challenge the limitations of his sound. It is this boldness that will provide a glorious addition to the line-up on the night. Nick Johnson is the final act to be revealed today. Johnson is a Trinity assistant professor in drama who broadcasts a weekly radio show on Trinity FM, entitled Plastic Soul, which he describes as "totally eclectic music" that is "theme led". Johnson will bring a live set of the show to the stage this year, suggesting in an interview with *The University Times* that his set will lean towards hip-hop. Trinity Ball will take place on Friday April 7th, with headliners to be announced on February 12th. Access to the ball will be available through Nassau St and Westland Row will also provide access from 9pm, with Front Gate closed due to Luas works.